

SEAL MILLIONS

With a population of more than 10 million, crabeater seals are the most numerous large wild mammals on Earth. They spend most of their time in the cold water or resting on the floating pack ice, sometimes in huge groups of up to 1,000 seals. The females also give birth on the ice in spring. They feed their pups on their rich milk for three weeks, until the pups are ready to enter the water and hunt for themselves.



▲ FLOATING REFUGE

A drifting ice floe makes an ideal retreat for these crabeater seals, safe from the leopard seals that are their main enemies.

Crabeater seals and penguins

The pack ice that forms on the Southern Ocean around Antarctica is home to millions of seals and penguins.

The most numerous are crabeater seals, which breed on the ice. Most penguins leave the ice to nest on Antarctic coasts and islands when the snow melts in summer.

But uniquely, emperor penguins breed on the coastal sea ice that extends from the shores of Antarctica in winter.



◀ KRILL STRAINER

Despite their name, crabeater seals feed almost exclusively on the small shrimplike krill that form huge swarms in the cold Southern Ocean. They strain the krill from the water using specialized teeth that interlock with each other to form a sieve.

FAST FACTS

- Baby crabeater seals put on weight at the rate of 9 lb (4 kg) a day, while they are feeding on their mothers' milk.
- When breeding, krill-eating chinstrap penguins have to catch one krill every six seconds to feed their chicks.
- Male emperor penguins go without food for up to 115 days, while they are incubating their eggs. The females take over when the chicks hatch.